waited for a Chinese response to their proposal for a discussion on Tibet. They prepared thoroughly for the negotiation with India and they started to change the facts on the ground. By mid-1952, this was almost complete and Zhou was able to inform Josef Stalin that the question of whether there should be Chinese troops in Tibet was moot because they were already at the border with India. [24]

While India was waiting for the Chinese to respond to their proposal of 13 February 1952, the Indian Mission in Lhasa sent another valuable input in April. They reported to New Delhi that the Chinese had told the Tibetans that they would shortly take up with India the question of their relations with Tibet, including the Tibetan claims to areas like Ladakh and Tawang. [25] The Indian Mission also reported that the Chinese representatives in Lhasa had told the Tibetans that they were waiting for a favourable opportunity to regain these areas, and till that time, this issue would remain alive. This was a very important piece of information because it spoke of the extensive claims on Indian territory by China. In doing so, it questioned the very basis of two Indian presumptions: first, that China not raising doubts about the boundary with India meant that it had acquiesced in the alignment of the frontier; and second, that if India did not raise this issue, the Chinese might not raise it either. This latest information from Lhasa, on the contrary, suggested that the Chinese were aware of Tibetan claims with respect to the boundary and territory, and were preparing to call the India–Tibet frontier into question at an appropriate time. It ought to have, at the very least, re-opened the premise upon which the Government of India had worked, namely that Chinese silence on the issue of India's northern frontier was tantamount to acceptance, or at least acquiescence, of its current alignment.